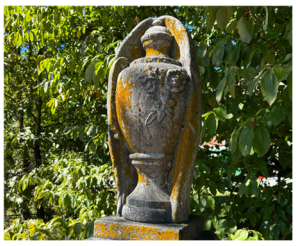
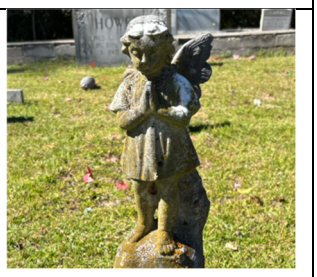
Mt. Carmel Cemetery Symbol Guide

Sunday, October 18, 2026

Flowers and bouquets	Flowers are among the most widespread cemetery decorations, expressing love, beauty, remembrance, and the brevity of life. Particular flowers acquired traditional associations: roses with love, lilies with purity and resurrection, and daffodils with renewal. Dogwood blossoms sometimes evoke a later Christian legend connecting the tree with Christ's crucifixion. Bouquets tied with ribbons may simply represent a lasting floral tribute.	
Ivy, vines, and foliage	Evergreen ivy is traditionally associated with enduring affection, fidelity, and remembrance because it remains green and clings firmly to its support. Vines may also suggest spiritual growth and continuity. Palm branches have a more specifically Christian association with victory over death, while other leafy forms may be primarily ornamental.	
Fraternal and organizational emblems	Emblems identify connections to religious, social, occupational, and fraternal organizations that played important roles in community life. At Mt. Carmel, examples include Freemasonry, the Order of the Eastern Star, railroad brotherhoods, the Loyal Order of Moose, the Shrine, The American Legion, among others. Such organizations often provided fellowship, mutual assistance, insurance benefits, and opportunities for civic participation. Their symbols can reveal aspects of a person's identity that ordinary inscriptions do not.	
Enclosed Graves	Some historical graves are surrounded by stone borders, curbing, or decorative posts. Common in nineteenth- and early twentieth-century cemeteries, these enclosures helped define and protect burial spaces from foot traffic or livestock. Some also served as flower beds or planting areas, although their original purpose is not always clear.	
Rock-faced stone	Rock-faced monuments emphasize the strength, stability, and permanence of stone, qualities with important biblical associations. In Psalm 18:2, God is described as a rock, fortress, and refuge ("The Lord is my rock, and my fortress, and my deliverer"). In Matthew 7:24–25, Jesus compares those who follow his teachings to a wise man who builds his house upon a rock. These passages suggest enduring faith, divine protection, and a firm spiritual foundation.	

Hearts	Hearts are enduring symbols of love, devotion, and affection. On gravestones they may express the bond between spouses, parents and children, or other loved ones. Their meaning is often personal rather than tied to a single religious tradition, emphasizing the emotional connection that survives death.	
Urns	Urns draw on ancient Greek and Roman funerary traditions and became especially popular in American cemetery design during the nineteenth century. Although they resemble vessels used to hold cremated remains, carved urns on gravestones generally serve as symbolic memorial objects rather than evidence of cremation. They evoke mortality, mourning, and remembrance.	
Drapery and veils	Carved fabric, often shown covering an urn or hanging across a monument, commonly represents grief and mourning. The veil may also suggest the separation between the visible world and the mystery of death. Drapery became a prominent feature of neoclassical memorial design, drawing on artistic traditions inherited from antiquity.	
Books	Open books frequently suggest the Bible, religious faith, or the Book of Life, in which the names of the redeemed are recorded. Books may also represent learning, wisdom, or the story of a person's life. The Bible also describes heavenly books recording human deeds (Revelation 20:12) and the Book of Life containing the names of those granted eternal life (Revelation 21:27).	
Scrolls	Scroll-shaped monuments and carved scrolls evoke written records, remembrance, and the preservation of a person's life story. In biblical tradition, scrolls are associated with sacred scripture, divine law, and God's promises. Some scroll designs, however, may be primarily decorative.	
Military symbols	Military headstones and carvings may record service, rank, unit, branch, or participation in a particular conflict. Flags and other patriotic emblems can express service and remembrance. Some markers were placed long after a person's death, so the date and origin of a monument may be important for understanding how military service was commemorated.	
Dove or bird	Doves have long been associated with peace and, in Christianity, the Holy Spirit. On gravestones they may suggest the soul's ascent to heaven, spiritual purity, or eternal rest. A dove carrying an olive branch also recalls the biblical account of Noah and symbolizes hope and renewal after hardship.	

Hands	Carved hands communicate several different messages. Praying hands represent devotion and faith; clasped hands may express marriage, affection, farewell, or reunion; and an upward-pointing hand can direct attention toward heaven. A hand breaking a chain may symbolize release from earthly bonds or the soul's liberation through death. Details of the gesture can help distinguish these meanings.	
Angels	Angels serve as messengers between Heaven and Earth and frequently represent divine protection, guidance, or the welcome of a soul into the afterlife. They became especially prominent in nineteenth-century cemetery sculpture. Earlier American gravestones, particularly in colonial New England, often featured skulls and other symbols emphasizing mortality.	
Crosses	The cross is, of course, Christianity's central symbol, representing Jesus' crucifixion, sacrifice, and resurrection. It appears in many forms, from simple Latin crosses to elaborate carved designs. Crosses on military headstones may also reflect a standardized religious emblem rather than a selection of the family.	
Lambs	Lambs are particularly associated with children's graves, where they symbolize innocence and gentleness. The image also draws on Christian traditions identifying Jesus as the Lamb of God and the Good Shepherd who watches over his flock.	
Gates	Gates often represent the entrance to heaven or the passage from earthly life into eternity. This imagery draws on biblical descriptions of the gates of heaven. Open gates may suggest welcome and salvation, while closed gates can emphasize the boundary between earthly and eternal existence.	
Crowns	Crowns represent victory, honor, and heavenly reward. Christian interpretations draw on biblical references to the "crown of life" promised to the faithful. A crown may therefore express the belief that the deceased has completed life's struggles and received an eternal reward.	
Logs and tree forms	Monuments carved to resemble logs, branches, or tree stumps became popular during the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, reflecting a broader interest in rustic and naturalistic design. Broken branches or cut trunks may suggest a life interrupted. Tree-trunk monuments were also used by Woodmen of the World, a fraternal benefit society, although the design alone does not establish membership.	

Follow the Mt. Carmel Cemetery on Instagram: https://www.instagram.com/mtc.cemetery/	**Visit the Mt. Carmel Cemetery Online:** https://www.mtcarmel-umc.org/cemetery-guide

Mt. Carmel Cemetery Symbol Hunt

Find as many different symbols as you can. For each, record the deceased's name and death year. A single gravestone may not count for multiple categories, except for the Multi-Symbol category, which should include a gravestone with three or more different motifs.

Flowers and bouquets	Ivy, vines, and foliage	Fraternal and organizational	Enclosed Graves	Rock-faced stone
Hearts	**Urns**	**Drapery and veils**	**Books**	**Scrolls**
Military symbols	**Dove or bird**	**Hands**	**Angels**	**Crosses**
Lambs	**Gates**	**Crowns**	**Logs and trees**	**Multi-Symbol**

Tie Breaker: What was the most distinctive grave marker in your search area?